HEAVY INDUSTRIES

GOING GREEN

It is time to phase out the support to electric vehicle makers as sustainable mobility gathers pace

By Anilesh S. Mahajan



Mahendra Nath Pandey
Minister of Heavy Industries

GETTY IMAGES

THERE IS SOME CONFIDENCE in the Mahendra Nath Pandey-led ministry's implementation of the Faster Adoption and Manufacturing of Hybrid and Electric Vehicles, or FAME 2. The government has greenlighted their proposal to start phasing out the support extended to electric vehicle manufacturers. From June 1, the existing support of Rs 15,000 per kWh has been reduced to Rs 10,000 per kWh. The maximum cap on subsidy is brought down from 40 per cent to 15 per cent of MRP.

The two phases of FAME—part of the National Electric Mobility Mission Plan—have already created some base in the electric two-wheeler space; 846,976 units were sold in FY23, 2.5 times more than in the previous fiscal. This is the nodal ministry that is pushing the silent electric mobility movement in the country. The FAME-2 scheme, which started on April 1, 2019 with an outlay of Rs 10,000 crore, will end in March next year. The target is to have 500,000 e-rickshaws, 1 million electric two-wheelers, 35,000 electric four-wheelers, 20,000 hybrid four-wheelers, 7,090 e-buses, along with 2,700 supporting charging stations.

Meanwhile, BHEL along with its consortium partner Titagarh Wagons Ltd in April, got orders to manufacture and supply 80 sleeper Vande Bharat train sets in the next 72 months. This is BHEL's entry into niche train set manufacturing capabilities. ■

LABOUR & EMPLOYMENT

Wooing the Workforce

Despite a slew of digitisation measures, expanding the jobs market is a daunting challenge

By Amarnath K. Menon

BOLD & BRAVE

5.9 MILLION

No. of insured women who can submit an online claim for maternity benefit on the ESIC portal

ON THE FACE OF IT, the figures look impressive. The eShram portal of the Bhupender Yadav-led labour ministry has registered a staggering 300 million workforce, about three-fourths of the total estimated unorganised workforce. eShram allows registration in 400 different occupations under 30 broad sectors. It is being integrated with the Skill India portal, enabling workers to avail of the various skilling initiatives.

However, there is little incentive for workers to register on eShram, thanks to the time and income lost in registration, or for employers to push them. The absence of credible and promised social security benefits is another dampener. Also, while Rs 708 crore has been spent to launch the portal, there is no proportional spend on popularising it.

Bhupender Yadav
Minister of Labour & Employment

The implementation of the four Labour Codes is another work in progress. They envisage strengthening the protection available to workers, including unorganised ones, in